

SOCIETIES

capital, raw materials for their factories, and markets for their new products, found them in Asia, Africa, and Latin America. They also sought land for their expanding populations to settle in thinly populated zones such as the North American plains and Australia. Peoples who stood in their way were swept aside. The Europeans started expanding the areas under their direct rule or control. The British takeover of the Indian subcontinent, more or less complete by the mid-19th century, was the most spectacular example of imperialism in action, and Sub-Saharan Africa was divided among the European powers as if the local population did not exist.

The world's response to Western imperialism was mixed. Resistance was widespread in the form of wars and uprisings against European dominance. On the other hand, the growing superiority of the West in technology, science, military power, and social organization led several non-European governments to try to modernize based on the Western model. In the Muslim world, Egypt, Turkey, and Iran attempted, with only partial success, to pursue a modernizing agenda. In East Asia, Japan successfully transformed itself into an efficient

modern state, becoming an imperialist power in its own right. China, by contrast, experienced turmoil and invasion, and imperial rule collapsed in the early 20th century.

Rising nationalism

Most Europeans and people of European descent gloried in a false sense of their own racial and cultural superiority to the rest of the world, but Europe remained a deeply divided continent. Militant nationalism, unleashed by the French Revolution, was a threat to stability. By 1815, the Napoleonic Wars had generated battles of unprecedented scale. After the wars of the mid-19th century that created a unified Italy and Germany, the great powers maintained large conscript armies and formed mutually hostile alliance systems. These armies were equipped with high-explosive shells and rapid-fire weapons.

European military power, which was supported by highly organized state systems and economies, was certainly one of the key elements in European world domination. There would be disaster when European states turned this power against one another. ■